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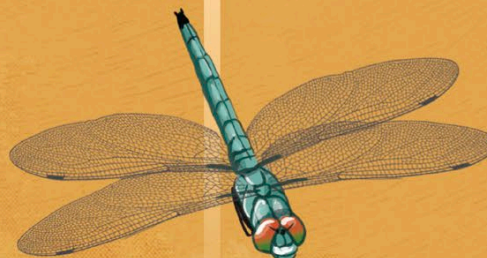
430
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Jaws!

The first vertebrates (backboned animals) were jawless fish that had appeared during the Cambrian explosion. Millions of years later, some evolved jaws that could bite. This turned them into fierce predators, including the first sharks.



Flying insects

Some of the creepy-crawlies on land evolved six legs and wings for flying—becoming the first insects. This was a winning move. Insects became the biggest group of animals, and hundreds of thousands of species filled the swelling vegetation as the land turned green.

Forests

As plants lived together, they grew taller to escape the shadows of their neighbors and reach more light. They evolved into the first trees, and the forests they built became important habitats for land animals.

Today's rain forests have different kinds of trees than prehistoric forests but are still home to many species.

The seven-gilled shark of today is a descendant of prehistoric sharks.



Land plants

Green algae and seaweed were already growing in shallow water, and these evolved into the first plants to grow on land. Mosses carpeted patches of ground, and the first creepy-crawlies made their home here.

Even today, Sphagnum moss dominates some wet, boggy habitats.

